fire is my first, very big and complicated memory. I remember lights and colours and incidents from before, but this was something else. It involved levels of human complication that would come to fascinate me. The locals seemed to take a certain delight in the idea of pretension and daring getting their comeuppance. I noticed, probably for the first time in my life, how authority could drag its heels to make a point and how bureaucracy could make a stone of the heart. There was something demonic in the way they let ‘nature’ take its course.

So, here was municipal power. And I was moved by it. It might seem invidious to look for sources of character in your life, but it might be counted forgivable in a journalist and essential in an autobiography. Early on, I became fascinated by how things work. As soon as I could handle the tools, I began picking engines apart. I began building rafts. I loved mechanical Lego. When I was six I tried to make a crude metal detector. That was my earliest sense of the world: as of its being a place where you could work things out, show a little scientific curiosity, build something new.

At an early stage I realised there was a social element to all this. I put a gang together, the better to get things done and have fun while doing it. We used to go to this large, defunct slate quarry. There had been a mine there but everything was abandoned: the storage sheds still stood, the hauling equipment and even, inside the sheds, the logbooks and all the paraphernalia of explosive devices and such. We’d go up there frequently. I suppose we saw it as our domain, a place where we could exist independently of authority. The rocks and abandoned sheds were covered in these scurrying lizards – blue-tongued lizards and skinks – and there were sometimes wallabies up there, too. The quarry was surrounded by a bamboo forest and sometimes I would take myself off alone to explore between the thick hollow trees. I remember fighting my way to the centre of it one very hot day. I felt alone but quite powerful in the effort to get through, and, when I made it, I got out my knife and carved my name on a thick chunk of bamboo. I went back there about eight years ago and was surprised to find how easy it was to move through the forest – although it didn’t diminish the power of those memories. My childhood stands out in my mind for its bigness, the vividness of its impressions, and I think that some of my desire to uncover the world’s hidden secrets comes from those early explorations.